Excerpt from Shyam Saran's: *How India Sees the World*

1. Sources of India's World View

In the Mahabharata, the narrator, Sanjaya, recalls for King Dhritarashtra the vision of the entire cosmos as a vast circle of seven concentric oceans separating six regions or *varshas* , each with its own mountains and river systems. At the centre lies Jambudvipa, described in other sacred texts as a four-petalled lotus floating in the ocean, with our own *varsha* , Bharata, defined by the southern petal. It has the Himalayas for its mountain system and mighty rivers, as do the other *varshas,* and seas surrounding its triangular shape. This is a landscape that is mythical yet hallowed, and also recognizably physical. It is a template ingrained in the collective Indian consciousness that continues to shape our view of the world around us – as it has through the centuries, irrespective of the rise and fall of empires. This vision has endured in our subconscious, prevailing over the political, social and cultural particularities that make India such a diverse country.

There are many in the West, and some in India too, who consider India an artificial construct. The British colonial administrator John Strachey declared in 1888:

> The first and most important thing to learn about India is that there is not and never was an India.

And yet India had a centralized empire under the Mauryas, covering much of the subcontinent at least a century before the Qin united only part of Han China. The distribution of Ashoka's pillars and rock edicts traces much of the same geography as the India under British colonial rule.

Alexander Cunningham, the British archaeologist who served in colonial India, cites the Greek historian Strabo on how the country beyond the Indus was described to Alexander of Macedon by those well acquainted with it: